ALTO FINANCIAL GROUP · ADVISOR GUIDE

Running a Fortress Blueprint

How to take a household from a list of statements to a client-ready Retirement Fortress design in about fifteen minutes.

Internal use Twenty-three sections, top to bottom No login, nothing installed

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Start
ORIENTATION

What the tool does

You give it a household's income picture and a list of their existing accounts. It sizes the four Fortress levels from those numbers, then maps every account to a destination — which registration it consolidates into, which carrier it ends up with, and what stays put. Out the other end come five documents: three for the client, two for the file.

It does *not* replace your judgment. The allocation it proposes is a starting point you are expected to override, and section 14 exists for exactly that.

Nothing is saved by itself

The tool has no autosave. Close the tab or hit refresh and the case is gone. On the claude.ai demo there is no account either: before you walk away, go to section 23, press `Copy case data`, and paste the block into your CRM note — that block is the only way back. On Alto's own site you sign in and press `Save` in section 23 instead; the case is kept on Alto's server under your name.

Everything opens with a +

The page loads with all twenty-three sections closed — a column of navy headers. Click a header, or its **+**, to open a section; inside, every subsection bar and every standalone table has its own **+** as well, and the year-by-year tables sit behind a **+** of their own. `Expand all sections` and `Collapse all sections` at the top do it in one go. Any `Add a …` button opens whatever it adds to, so a new row is never hidden. Every action button on the page is green; the only exceptions are the × that removes a row and the **+/−** toggles.

The page opens empty — a new case, every field blank, today's date in section 01. To pick up a household, press `Load case` in the top right and open its case file (the .json or .txt from

`Download case file`, or a Word .docx of the household) — the same as `Upload case file` in section 23 — or paste its block from section 23 into `Load pasted case`. `Start new case` in the top right — twice, it asks you to confirm — empties every field again; your name and the date carry over, the client's details do not. There is no sample household in the page; a training copy can be opened with one by defining `RFB_DEFAULT_CASE` ahead of the script, which the repository notes describe.

Levels
REFERENCE

The four levels, and how the tool sizes them

The framework in one table — the same description appears in the Retirement Fortress Plan report. Send clients to the whitepaper for the full version.

LEVEL	WHAT IT HOLDS	HOW THE TOOL SIZES IT
Roof WISHES	Growth and legacy assets	The residual — whatever the other three do not need
Walls WANTS	Balanced market investments	The higher of 24 months of Needs, or (Wants less non-guaranteed income) ÷ the Walls yield
Foundation NEEDS	Cash buffer, plus guaranteed income	Buffer = months × Needs ÷ 12. Annuity = the Needs gap over the first 15 years of retirement — the highest month as a year, or the average, per section 03 (projected before the plan: Needs with inflation against Social Security with its COLA, pensions and annuity income) ÷ the Foundation yield
Moat PROTECTION	Long-term care contracts	Benefit ÷ an age ratio: 3.2 at 55, 3.17 at 60, 3.1 at 65, interpolated for every age between and beyond

> **The Moat here is narrower than the framework's**
>
> In the whitepaper the Moat defends against long-term care *and* tax drag. This tool sizes only the long-term care piece. Withdrawal sequencing, Roth conversions and asset location are still your job, and the Retirement Fortress Plan report says the tax side is handled in how and when income is drawn.

01

INPUT

Prepared by

The first thing on the page: your name and the date. Both print on the client PDF and the worksheet, and the date sets the plan's first year for the projections. The `Advisor` name carries from case to case; the `Date prepared` resets to today whenever you start a new case.

02

INPUT

Client information

Who the plan is for. Names print on every document and drive the filenames.

Client and spouse

First and last name, age and sex for each. Age and sex set the long-term care benefit defaults in sections 08 and 09. Leave every spouse field blank for a single client and nothing in the plan is titled Joint or Spouse.

`State of residency`

Sets the state income tax model in section 17 and is recorded for the file. Product approval is by state, so check it against the carrier before anything in section 20 goes to paper.

Dependents

`Add adult dependent` and `Add minor dependent` take a first name and an age each. They do not enter the Fortress sizing, but their ages drive the life insurance need in section 08 — years of income replacement and education funding — and they travel with the case so the file is complete.

03

INPUT

Plan assumptions

The rates and choices the whole plan is built on, kept in one place so they are easy to review before a client sees anything. They are planning assumptions, not quotes, and the Retirement Fortress Plan's disclosures carry whatever you set here.

`Liquidity buffer`

Months of Needs held in cash. Defaults to 6. Sized on *full* Needs, not the gap.

`Foundation sizing method` and `window (N)`

How the Needs gap that sizes the Foundation annuity is measured, and over how many years of retirement: *Average Needs gap over N years* (the default) or *Peak monthly Needs gap in the first N years*, with N 5 by default. The tool runs the status-quo projection — nothing moved, no annuity bought — and for each of the first N full calendar years with everyone retired takes that year's Needs (growing with inflation, dated budget lines honoured) less that year's Social Security with its COLA, pensions and annuity income already in place. On the peak method the largest of those gaps — the highest monthly shortfall, taken as a year in the dollars of that year — divided by the Foundation yield is the annuity target, so a level payment covers the gap in

every year of the window and runs ahead of it in the others. On the average method the mean of the gaps is used instead: a smaller target that runs a little behind the gap in the costliest years and ahead in the rest. Section 04 shows today's gap and the other measure beside the sizing figure, and the section 13 note gives the peak year. Shorten the window to size on the early years, lengthen it to cover more of the inflation drift.

Yields

`Foundation yield` and `Walls yield`, both 6.0% by default. The Foundation yield turns the sizing Needs gap into a Foundation target; the Walls yield turns Wants into a Walls target. Change them if the products you actually place justify it.

`Guaranteed lifetime income`

The default for every Foundation annuity in the projections; section 14 can set each contract on its own. A contract's value falls by the income it pays each year either way (no crediting is assumed). With **Yes** — the default, a lifetime-income contract — the payment continues for life after the value reaches zero. With **No** the contract pays a monthly share of its value and the payment stops once the value is gone, so Foundation income drops in the years that follow and the Roof carries more of Needs. Sections 15 and 17 and the Retirement Fortress Plan report all follow the setting; the sizing in section 13 does not change.

Growth rates

`Walls growth rate` (1.5% by default) is what the Walls balance is assumed to grow at after its income is drawn, and `Roof growth rate` (6.0%) is the Roof's assumed growth. Neither changes the sizing in section 13; both drive the projection chart there — Walls income rising with the Walls, and the Roof balance column.

`Inflation`

What Needs and Wants grow at in the projection. Defaults to 3.0%. The tax projection in section 17 indexes the brackets and deductions at the same rate.

`End of plan age`

The age of the *younger* client when the plan ends; 100 by default. It sets how far the income projection in section 13 and the tax projection in section 17 run.

Medicare

`Medicare Part B` and `Medicare Part D`, monthly per person. They default to the 2026 figures — the $202.90 standard Part B premium and the $38.99 Part D base beneficiary premium — and feed the Medicare lines in the section 05 worksheet. Standard premiums only: a household over the IRMAA thresholds pays more, so raise them for that client.

`New custodian`

Where Step 1 of the transfer sequence consolidates everything: Schwab or Fidelity.

`Life insurance cash value`

No leaves existing policies alone. **Yes** puts their cash value toward the Moat by 1035 exchange — and because a 1035 has to keep the same owner, each policy can only fund that person's

own contract.

04
INPUT

Income

The income side of the sizing — this section and the Needs and Wants in section 05 together drive everything downstream, so both are worth getting right before you touch the accounts.

It opens with an **Employment income** table, one column per person: annual salary, target retirement date, annual payroll deductions, the employee and employer retirement contributions as percentages of salary, which account from section 06 each lands in — the employee's contribution and the employer's match have their own destinations, so a Roth 401(k) deferral and a pre-tax match are kept apart (the employer's blank means the same account) — and the annual salary increase. The contributions are deposited into those accounts each working year in every projection, growing with them, and an employee contribution into a Roth account is taxed as wages; a line with no destination is treated as not saved, and the table says so. Beneath it the tool works out each person's **net before-tax annual salary** (salary less payroll deductions and the employee contribution), the dollars going into retirement accounts each year, and the time to retirement with the salary projected to that date. These describe the working years and are recorded for the plan; the Fortress sizing runs off the retirement figures that follow.

Under it, **Additional employment income** takes any number of further paychecks for either person — a second job, part-time or consulting work in retirement, a board seat. Each line has a name, whose it is, the gross annual amount in today's dollars, a start date (blank: already paying), an end date (blank: that person's target retirement date when they have one still ahead, otherwise through the plan) and an annual increase. The note beneath each line reads it back, and the hint totals what is paying now. These incomes count as wages on their own dates in the income gap, the tax projection, the status quo and the reports (they appear as rows on the Employment income table of the Retirement Fortress Plan and in the Household income tile); no payroll deductions or retirement contributions are assumed on them, and they do not move the retirement dates. Tick `Self-employed` on a line for consulting or practice income and the projections charge self-employment tax on it instead of the employee's payroll tax, deducting half of it from income. They save with the case.

Payroll taxes are taken automatically in every projection, so `Payroll deductions` is for benefits only: on each person's gross salary (retirement deferrals do not reduce it) and on the additional lines, 6.2% Social Security tax to the 2026 wage base of $184,500, indexed with the plan's inflation, 1.45% Medicare on every dollar, and the 0.9% Additional Medicare tax on household wages over $200,000 (single) or $250,000 (joint), which is not indexed. Self-employed lines pay 12.4% and 2.9% on 92.35% of the income, sharing the wage base with any wages. The payroll tax appears in the section 04 salary breakdown, as its own column in the cash flow and tax tables while anyone is working, and in the lifetime totals; the Fortress sizing, which runs off the retirement figures, is not affected.

Next comes **Social Security and pension income**. For Social Security enter each person's `Primary Insurance Amount` from their SSA statement, the age they will start benefits (62 to 70) and one COLA assumption (2.5% by default); the tool applies the SSA's own early-claiming reduction or delayed credits against a full retirement age worked out from the age in section 02, and shows the monthly benefit in today's dollars and what COLA makes of it by the start age. When the lower earner's PIA is under half of the higher earner's, the tool adds the spousal top-up — half the higher PIA less their own, reduced on the SSA's spousal schedule if claimed early, with no delayed credits — and notes that it is payable only once the higher earner has filed.

Under the Social Security table, the **Claiming optimizer** tests every claiming age from 62 to 70 (plus full retirement age) for each person — 72 combinations for a couple — paying each one out month by month to an assumed lifespan with the SSA's early-claiming reductions and delayed credits, the spousal top-up and deemed filing, and the survivor benefit (the larger of the two, with the 82.5% floor), COLA applied each January. It takes the PIAs, ages, names and COLA already on the page; you add only each person's `life expectancy` (blank: 85 for a man, 88 for a woman), an optional `discount rate` (blank ranks nominal totals; equal to the COLA ranks in today's dollars) and, optionally, dates of birth for month-level precision — otherwise ages are whole years from section 02. With `Rank with the trust-fund stress test` ticked the strategies are ranked on the 22%-from-2032 reduction used in section 19, with the no-cut total alongside. Tiles name the top strategy, its lifetime benefit, the surviving spouse's income under it, and where the plan's own claiming ages rank among everything tested; the table always lists the same six scenarios in the same order, each with its true rank among everything tested: **1 Highest lifetime benefit**; **2 File late**, both at 70; **3 File early**, both at 62; **4** the client early at 62 and the spouse late at 70; **5** the client late at 70 and the spouse early at 62; **6 File at full retirement age**, both at FRA (a single person gets 1, 2, 3 and 6; a person already past an age files at the earliest age still open to them; a scenario whose ages match an earlier one says so). Each shows the person's monthly amounts, lifetime totals and the age at which it catches up to filing earliest; a chart runs the cumulative benefits (the plan's own ages as a dashed line when they are not among the scenarios), and `Break-even ages` opens the full scenario-versus-scenario table. `Use the top strategy in the plan` sets the benefit starting ages above to strategy #1 (whole years), so the income projections, the Foundation sizing and every report follow. The optimizer's settings save with the case. Not modelled: the earnings test, tax on benefits, WEP/GPO, restricted applications, disability or dependent benefits.

Pensions are a list: `Add a pension` for each one either person will receive — a name, whose it is, the monthly amount in today's dollars, start date, COLA and the survivor percentage (0 to 100) — with a note under each line and totals by person. **Other guaranteed income** is a third list for annuities already paying out or scheduled to — `Add an annuity income` gives a name, whose it is, the monthly amount, start date, an end date or `Life`, COLA, survivor percentage and the account in section 06 that holds the contract; a contract whose end date has passed is shown but left out of the total. All three roll straight into the household figures the Foundation is sized from — there is nothing to copy or apply. A fourth list, **Non-guaranteed income**, records rents, royalties, part-time work or business income — name, whose (including joint), monthly amount, start, end or `Ongoing`, annual increase and a note. It never closes the Foundation gap, which only guaranteed income may do, but it does pay for Wants: the Walls are sized on Wants

less this income, so a rental covering part of the discretionary budget shrinks the Walls target accordingly (the 24-month Needs floor still applies).

The section closes with **Your income today and in retirement**, the same summary the Retirement Fortress Plan report carries: four tiles — household income today, guaranteed income in retirement, the share of Needs it covers and the **Annual Needs income gap** the Foundation annuity is sized to close — a table setting Social Security, pensions and annuity income against Annual Needs, and a **Sources of income** chart stacking salaries, Social Security, pensions, annuity and non-guaranteed income year by year as the plan stands today, before the Fortress is built. The note beneath gives the first full retirement year's figures; the shortfall against expenses is the Income Gap chart in section 05.

Carriers

There is no carrier field to fill. The Foundation annuity is assumed to go to the carrier of the largest annuity in section 06, and the Moat contract to the carrier of the largest life or LTC policy there. No such account, or no custodian typed on it, and the documents read "TBD" with a flag until you pick a carrier on the line in section 14 — fine for a first pass, not for anything you hand over.

05

INPUT

Expenses

The section opens with the two figures everything is sized from, and the detailed worksheet folded away beneath them.

`Annual Needs`

Essential expenses — what the household costs before anything optional. This one number drives the buffer, the Foundation and the Walls floor.

`Annual Wants`

Travel, gifts, entertainment. What they would rather not cut first. The Walls are sized on Wants less any non-guaranteed income from section 04.

Type both straight in from a client's own figures, or press the green `Complete Detailed Expenses` bar to open Alto's monthly budget worksheet, line for line — six categories from Household to Entertainment & other, with three *Other* lines you can name and an `+ Add line` button on every category heading for an expense the worksheet has no row for (a name, an amount, a Need/Want switch, dates and a note like any other line; the × at its right removes it). Enter monthly amounts. Each line carries a `Need / Want` switch, preset the way most households would answer (mortgage and groceries are Needs; dining out and travel are Wants); change any of them. Start and end dates shape the arithmetic: a line counts in today's Needs and Wants — the total at the foot of the worksheet, the figures it applies above, the Foundation sizing — only while its dates cover the month the plan starts, and the year-by-year projections carry each line on its own dates, so a mortgage that ends in 2031 drops out of the expenses then and a tuition line that starts next autumn comes in then. A line outside today's

figures is struck through with a note under its date, and the footer shows the all-lines total beside today's. Notes are for the file.

Under *Healthcare & insurance* the worksheet carries four lines it fills for you: **Medicare Part B** and **Part D** for each person, at the premiums set in section 03, with a start date of the month each person turns 65 worked out from the ages in section 02 (blank once they are 65 already). They are shown in grey while they are defaults; type over an amount or a start date and that line is yours and stops following. A single client gets two lines, not four. On their own the Medicare defaults do not count as a budget — the apply button waits for a line you entered yourself — but they are in the totals from the first line you add.

Under the table the budget rolls up into annual **Needs** and **Wants** next to what the two fields above currently hold. `Apply to Annual Needs & Wants` copies them up once; tick `Keep Annual Needs & Wants in sync` and every budget edit updates the fields as you type. Leave both alone and the fields keep whatever you entered. The green `Complete Detailed Expenses` bar folds the worksheet and its upload box away again with its +/−; the bar itself keeps the monthly total and the two annual figures in view, and a case with budget lines reopens with the worksheet showing.

> **The worksheet is optional**
>
> It is there for the household that has not done the budgeting work. Everything in it saves and reloads with the case.

Start and end dates are honoured in the projections. While the budget is the source of Annual Needs and Wants — kept in sync, or the two figures still equal to its totals — every year-by-year projection (the income gap, the status quo, the Fortress projection, the tax table) counts each line only between its start and end months, pro-rated to the month in the first and last year: a mortgage line ending June 2041 is half a year's payments in 2041 and nothing after, Medicare begins the month each person turns 65, and a line with no dates runs for the whole plan. The annual totals shown in the section, and the Foundation sizing in section 13, still use every line in full — so the Foundation is sized to today's Needs as before. Type over Annual Needs or Wants and the projections fall back to those flat figures. Debt maturities in section 07 are independent: end the budget line yourself when the loan clears.

The first plan year is prorated. The plan starts in the month of the `Date prepared` in section 01, so the first row of every projection carries only the rest of that calendar year — three months for a plan prepared in October — for income and expenses alike: salaries, Social Security, pensions, annuity and other income, the Walls yield and the Foundation annuity on the income side, Needs and Wants (and each dated budget line) on the other. Income tax for that year is still figured on the whole calendar year, since brackets are annual: the plan carries its share of the year's tax in proportion to its income (the rest was withheld before the plan), and any Roth conversion in that year is taxed at the margin on top of the full year's income — so the converter sees the real headroom, not a quarter-year's. The assumptions notes under the projections say which month the plan runs from.

Beneath the budget sits the **Income Gap** chart: every source of income as it stands today — salaries to each retirement date, Social Security, pensions, annuity and other income on their own dates — as a blue bar for each year, total expenses as a line, and the shortfall where expenses outrun income drawn in red on top of the bar, labelled every fifth year. The tiles above it give the year the gap first appears, the gap at full retirement, the largest gap and the total over the plan: the figure the Fortress is built to fund. It runs before any Fortress is built, so advisor adjustments in section 14 do not move it; the same chart is the Income Gap page of the Retirement Fortress Plan report.

06
INPUT

Assets

Three ways in. Pick whichever suits the case:

01 **Upload a spreadsheet.** Press `Download template` for the Alto account template, fill it in, then drop it on the panel or use `Choose file`. You get a preview before anything lands — then `Replace table` or `Add to table`. CSV works too.

02 **Paste rows.** Open `Or paste rows instead` and paste straight from a spreadsheet. Tab- or comma-separated, same column order, header row skipped automatically.

03 **Type them.** `Add account` for one row at a time. Fastest for a household with four or five accounts.

Two columns decide more than they look like they do:

- `Tax type` drives the whole waterfall. Qualified, Roth and Non-Qualified money go to different levels in a different order — get this wrong and the design is wrong.
- `Current position` tells the tool what it is looking at. Mark bank savings and money market as **Cash** — that is what the liquidity buffer keys on, and a household with no Cash row gets no buffer. **Annuity** and **LTC / Life** get their own handling for assignments and 1035s.

The `Transfer?` column at the end holds an account back. Set it to **Stay as is** and that account still takes its place in the Fortress levels but stays at its institution, generates no paperwork, and drops out of the billable base — the fee note names the amount so nothing hides. **Transfer part** opens an amount box: only that much of the account enters the plan and the waterfall; the rest stays where it is, held outside the plan at the account's own growth rate, shown as *Held as is* on the scenario cards and out of the billable base.

Excess cash flow, beneath the table, picks the account or accounts a year's income left over after expenses and tax is deposited into in the projections — after-tax money, so the list offers the taxable and Roth accounts. Several split it equally. With nothing picked the surplus goes to the household's **Cash** accounts (savings, checking, money market, in equal shares), shown with

a dashed outline as the default; a household with no Cash account banks nothing until one is picked (spare RMD money is still reinvested in the after-tax Roof account).

The `Growth` column is each account's assumed annual growth. Leave it blank (*default*) and the account takes the plan rate from section 03 for the level its money lands in — the Walls rate for the Walls and for anything that stays as is, the Roof rate for the Roof. Type a rate and it is blended into that level's growth in proportion to the account's share, so the projections in sections 16, 15 and 17 follow it; the assumptions line under each one shows the blended rates.

Other assets

A second panel under the accounts for real assets outside the Fortress — primary residence, vacation home, rental property, land, a business interest, vehicles or other real assets — each with a value and an assumed appreciation rate. They do not enter the levels or the projections (nothing in them is invested), but they complete the balance sheet: the **Net worth** readout is the accounts plus these, less the debts in section 07, and both print in the worksheet. Rent from a rental property belongs in Non-guaranteed income in section 04, and the mortgage on a home in section 07.

Projected assets before the Fortress

The status quo, for comparison with section 18: every account left where it is and grown at its own rate (or, by default, cash flat, annuities at the Walls rate and market accounts at the Roof rate), current income — salary to each retirement date, Social Security, pensions, annuity and non-guaranteed income — against the Needs and Wants budget growing with inflation, and any gap drawn in the section 17 withdrawal order with the tax on the draw. Five tiles; two donut charts of today's accounts — **Qualified vs. non-qualified** (Qualified and Roth tax types, with the Roth share noted, against Non-Qualified) and **At risk vs. not at risk** (Market positions, RILA and variable annuities against cash, MYGA and fixed indexed annuities, life and LTC; an Unassigned position counts as not at risk and the card says so) — each with the dollar amounts and the share of the total; a stacked bar by tax type for every year with the retired years shaded and the first RMD year marked, a note that sets the end-of-plan figure against the Fortress projection, and a year-by-year table behind a **+**. It runs on the same engine as section 18 and prints in the worksheet.

If something goes wrong before the plan

Under the status-quo chart, the same projection run again under the three section 19 stresses, one at a time: three bad market years at the start of retirement (the market money takes the Roof's bad years where it sits; cash, fixed annuities and MYGAs behave as they do in the plan), the Social Security cut, and higher inflation. Each has its tiles, chart and a sentence; the dashed line is the projection above. They print as *If Nothing Changes and Something Goes Wrong* in the Retirement Fortress Plan, after the status-quo page, and as three small charts on page two of the initial observations and findings.

If a long term care event occurs

Under the status-quo chart, the same projection run again with a care event added, as a set of three charts: the male needs care, the female needs care, both need care (one chart for a single

client). Costs come from the section 12 estimate — the state medians or the costs typed there, the average durations for a man and a woman, the care start age and the cost inflation — at **70%** of the projected cost when one person needs care and **49%** of the combined cost when both do, net of any benefits already in force. With no Fortress in place the whole cost comes out of the accounts in the withdrawal order, with the tax on the draw. Each chart carries tiles for the cost of care, what is drawn from the accounts and the end-of-plan figure (or the year the accounts run out), and the projection without a care event as a dashed line for comparison. The charts need a current age in section 02 for each person.

07

INPUT

Debts

One line per obligation — mortgage, HELOC, credit card, signature loan, auto loan, student loan or other — with the lender or a description, the **balance**, the annual **interest rate**, the **monthly payment** and the **maturity** (leave it blank for a card or any revolving line). `Add a debt` starts a new line; the × removes one.

Under each line the tool works out how much of the payment is interest at today's balance, how long that payment takes to clear the debt and how much more interest it costs on the way, and whether that lands before, after or in line with the maturity. A line at 10% or more is marked as high-rate debt. The footer totals the balances, the weighted rate and the payments, and the readout splits mortgage and HELOC balances from everything else.

> **Where the numbers go**
>
> The balances carry straight into section 08: while this section has a line, the `Mortgage balance` and `Other debts` fields in the life insurance analysis read from here and cannot be typed over. The payments are *not* added to the expense budget in section 05 — the budget is your own worksheet, so enter them there if it should carry them. Debts travel with the case and print in the worksheet under *Debts*.

08

INPUT

Life Insurance

Alto's Coverage Needs Analyzer, built in with a column for each person. The section opens with the two `Existing life insurance` fields — the death benefit already in force, individual and group combined — and a readout of the additional coverage recommended; the green `Complete Detailed Life Insurance Needs Analysis` bar opens the rest, and a case that used it reopens with it showing.

Household obligations

`Mortgage balance`, `Other debts` and `College savings`. They are owed whichever person dies first, so they count in full against each person's need.

Planning assumptions

`Income replacement` (70% of salary), `Net discount rate` (2.00%, the return after inflation on the death benefit), the age dependents are `independent` (22), `College cost per child` ($120,000 for four years) and `Final expenses` ($15,000 per person).

Need by person

Salary comes from section 04, age from section 02. Tick whether the `spouse relies on this income` — replacement then runs to that person's target retirement age from section 04 (65 if none), or until the youngest dependent in section 02 reaches independence, whichever is longer; type a `years of income` figure to override. The need is the present value of the replaced income plus the mortgage, other debts, education not yet saved for (full cost for each dependent under 18, prorated for one already in college) and final expenses. Less the coverage in force, the gap is rounded up to the nearest $25,000 as the **recommended additional coverage**, with a term length suggested from the years of need and the person's age.

Underwriting outlook

Set each person's `health` class estimate, `tobacco` use and whether `employer group life` is part of the coverage in force. The notes beneath flag the carrier's financial ceiling (a multiple of income that falls with age), rated or decline risks, portability of group coverage, term availability by age and laddering ideas. They are planning estimates; the carrier decides.

> **On the worksheet only**
>
> The need by person, the breakdown, the underwriting notes and the assumptions print in the internal worksheet under *Life insurance needs*; the Retirement Fortress Plan report carries the summary. The estimate ignores Social Security survivor benefits, a surviving spouse's own income and taxes unless you reflect them in the inputs.

09
INPUT

Long Term Care

The section opens with the two `Average LTC cost` fields that size the Moat, the Moat premium readout, and Alto's Long-Term Care Needs Estimator folded away behind the green `Complete Detailed Long Term Care Needs Analysis` bar. Press it and two blocks open beneath; a case that used the analysis reopens with it showing.

Average LTC cost to plan for

The long-term care need per person, which the Moat is sized to cover. By default it is the average lifetime cost of care from age 65 (HHS ASPE: $85,400 for a man, $154,300 for a woman) grown at 4.5% a year from the person's current age in section 02 to age 80 — about $188,600 for a 62-year-old man, $372,100 for a 60-year-old woman — and it follows the age

and sex as you change them, until you type over it, or press `Use the uncovered need as the LTC benefit` to take the estimate (rounded to the nearest $1,000); that works whether or not the analysis is open, and a line beneath the buttons shows the current estimate. Tick `Keep the LTC benefits in sync` and they follow the estimate as you change it. Set a spouse benefit to 0 to plan for one person only.

Care cost assumptions

Annual costs in today's dollars for in-home care, assisted living and a nursing home, filled from the state medians in the CareScout Cost of Care Survey 2025 for the state in section 02 (national medians if the state has no data). `Care cost inflation` (4.5%), the nursing home `room` type, the `memory-care premium` (25%, applied to assisted living where cognitive decline is expected) and the `in-home care hours` (44 a week) shape them. Type over any cost to use a local quote; `Reset to state medians` puts the defaults back.

Care need by person

One column each. Set the `assumed age care begins` (80) and whether there is a `family history of cognitive decline`. The years in each setting fill from sex and that answer, following the HHS (ASPE) planning figures — about 3.7 years of care for women and 2.2 for men, more with cognitive decline — and show in grey until you type over them. Enter any `existing LTC coverage` as a monthly benefit. The footer works out years of care, the monthly cost when care begins, the projected cost in future dollars (and today's), what existing benefits cover and the **uncovered need**; a table beneath breaks each person's cost down by setting. Care is modelled in sequence — home, then assisted living, then nursing home — inflated from today to the year each part is paid; existing benefits are treated as a level monthly amount, not inflated.

> **The detail is on the worksheet**
>
> The estimate, its cost basis and the HHS duration note print in the internal worksheet under *Long-term care estimate*. The Retirement Fortress Plan report shows the projection table, the benefit and the Moat premium.

10

INPUT

Legacy Planning

Six client questions, most with *When was it last updated?* as a four-digit year beside them: *Do you have a will (or wills)?*, *Do you have a revocable trust?*, *Is your revocable trust funded?* (shown only when there is a trust), *Do you have a power of attorney (or powers of attorney)?*, *Do you have a medical power of attorney (or powers of attorney)?* and *Do you have beneficiaries listed on each of your investment accounts?*. The status line works out how many years since each was reviewed, and the readout flags what the answers suggest: no will or trust on file, documents or powers of attorney more than five years old, a trust not fully funded, a power of attorney or medical power of attorney missing or held by one person only, or beneficiary designations missing, incomplete or not reviewed in five years.

> **It feeds the risks**
>
> The three estate boxes in section 12 — no estate plan, estate plan more than five years out of date, missing or stale beneficiaries — read their supporting line from these answers and are suggested when the answers point to them. The answers save with the case and print in the worksheet under *Estate plan*.

11

DRAFT

Goals

Drop in the meeting notes — a `.txt`, `.md` or `.docx` file, or pasted text — and press `Draft goals from the notes`. The tool writes three to five client goals in the client's own terms, each a short title and a sentence or two, ordered by what matters most to them. Opened inside Claude, the drafting is done by Claude from the whole of the notes and asks your permission the first time (it uses your own Claude account); anywhere else, or if you decline, it reads the notes' own *Goals* heading and falls back to the sentences that read like goals.

Every goal is editable in place — retitle it, rewrite it, remove it, or `Add a goal` of your own. A card notes whether it was drafted, read from the notes, or written by you. Goals and the notes save with the case.

> **A draft, not a record**
>
> Read every goal against the notes before it goes on anything a client sees. The drafter does not invent facts, but it can misread a tangent as an intention, and the notes themselves may hold things the client said in passing.

12

INPUT

Risk

Two scores on a 1–100 scale — the client's `current risk score` from the questionnaire or portfolio analysis, and their `risk tolerance` — with the gap read out beneath. Then the risks the advisor identifies in the current situation, ticked from a fixed list, plus any added by hand. Two green sub-section bars sit between the scores and the risk list: `Complete the Risk Profile Questionnaire` (eleven questions that produce a 1–99 score on the Risk Number scale and fill the risk tolerance) and `Upload the Nitrogen Wealth Report`; each folds with its +/−.

Upload the Nitrogen Wealth Report

Press `Upload Nitrogen report` and choose the PDF of the client's current-portfolio analysis (a text file works too). The page reads the PDF's text itself — nothing is sent anywhere — and summarises the portfolio in aggregate: the Risk Number, the 95% historical range in percent and dollars, the portfolio value and number of positions, yield and expense ratio, the allocation by

asset class, the largest positions and every stress test the report shows, each against its benchmark, and the report's **Performance Analysis**: the modeled-performance chart (the portfolio's cumulative return against the benchmark's, read back from the PDF's own drawing and redrawn here), the trailing returns for 3 months to 10 years, and the statistics table — total return, standard deviation, drawdown, Sharpe, Sortino, beta, alpha, R^2, batting average and the up/down capture. The chart and tables print in the Retirement Fortress Plan as *Your Portfolio Against Its Benchmark*, right after the current-portfolio page. Inside Claude the summary is drafted by Claude from the report text, with a plain-language paragraph; elsewhere the figures are read by their labels. The text appears under `Report text` for checking, and can be edited or pasted in and re-analysed with `Analyze the text below` (a scanned, image-only PDF has no text to read). Two numbers are filled into the cells above automatically: the portfolio's Risk Number becomes the `current risk score` and the client's own Risk Number (*Your Risk Number*, from the questionnaire) becomes the `risk tolerance`, so the risk gap reads out at once. The report gains a page, *Your Current Investment Portfolio* (no vendor is named on it), after the risks: both Risk Numbers with the gap, the 95% range, value, yield and cost, the allocation and the stress tests. Upload, text and summary save with the case; `Clear` removes them.

Identified risks

Thirteen boxes: portfolio risk exceeding tolerance (the point gap is filled in), sequence risk (the share of assets in market positions in section 06 is filled in), the current portfolio underperforming its benchmark (from the Wealth Report's Performance Analysis: the modeled total return against the benchmark over the report's period, or the chart's end points, and how many of the trailing periods the portfolio trailed in — suggested when the total return is behind or most trailing periods are), no long-term care plan, no strategic tax plan, no written retirement plan, life insurance short of the needs analysis, no withdrawal order plan, no Foundation income to cover Needs, no Walls income to cover Wants, no estate plan, an estate plan more than five years old, and missing or stale beneficiaries. Each carries a line read from the plan — the Moat and benefit sized, the life coverage gap, how much of Needs guaranteed income covers today, the estate answers from section 10 — and where the data points to the risk a red note says so; the advisor still decides what to tick.

Additional risks

`Add a risk` gives a line to describe anything else, with its own tick box. Scores, ticks and added risks save with the case and print in the worksheet under *Risk tolerance and identified risks*.

13

READ

Retirement Fortress Target Allocations

Nothing to fill in — this is where you check the design holds up. Each bar is a level's target on a shared dollar scale; the filled part is what the tax-type waterfall funds from the accounts on its own. Hover any bar for the arithmetic behind it.

This is the **model's** allocation and it stays put: nothing you do in section 14 changes a bar or a tile here, so the two sections can always be read side by side. The plan as you have adjusted it

is in section 15.

A gap here is information, not an error. It usually means one of three things: there is not enough eligible money of the right tax type, the yields are optimistic, or the Wants figure is doing more work than the household's assets can support. The Roof shows "residual" because it has no target of its own.

14

OVERRIDE

Advisor Adjustments & Transfers

From here the plan branches into **three scenarios** — A in green, B in yellow, C in purple. Each carries its own adjusted transfers, annuity income and LTC benefit terms, Roof growth rates, Walls assumptions, withdrawal order and Roth strategy; everything above section 14 is shared. The tabs at the top of the section switch between them, and sections 14–20 take the colour of the one showing, with its name on every header. **Baseline and three scenarios side by side** beneath the tabs sets their headline figures in columns — the four levels funded (the Foundation figure includes the liquidity buffer, with the buffer's share noted), annuity income, LTC benefit, Roth conversions, withdrawal order, lifetime tax and assets at the end of plan, then the assets at the end of plan under each of the three section 19 stress tests and under each section 18 care-event projection, or the year they run out — each with a `View` button and a `Use for reports` pick. A fourth column on the left, **Baseline** in slate, is the client's accounts as they stand today with no plan applied — the status quo of section 06 — run through the same stress tests and care events, so every scenario is measured against where the client is now. It shows the money held as is, any annuity income and LTC coverage already in force, the blended growth of the accounts as held, and no Roth conversions; in its sequence-of-returns test the market money takes the Roof's bad years where it sits. It needs a growth rate on every account in section 06, like the status-quo projection. Rename a scenario in the `Name` box; `Copy this scenario into…` duplicates the one showing into another slot as a starting point. An untouched scenario follows the model's own proposal.

The waterfall proposes. You decide. The list is already on screen — one line per transfer, exactly what the waterfall placed. Until you edit it, it follows the household numbers above: change Annual Needs or the buffer and it re-flows.

Each row is one transfer. You set the **from account**, the **Fortress level** and the **transfer amount**; the tool proposes the **to account**, **custodian or carrier** and **product**, and you can pick a different one from each list or choose `Custom…` and type your own — a changed one is shaded, with the model's suggestion noted under it. The tax type sits under both the from account and the to account, so a Qualified-to-Roth or Qualified-to-Non-Qualified line stands out at a glance. The **starting balance** on each line is what the account still holds when that line is reached — its full value on its first line, then the remaining-after of its last line above (the full value is noted beneath) — so a second or third transfer from the same account shows what it actually has left to give. Moat transfers are listed one line per insured — a joint account funding both contracts shows two lines, "… → David LTC Contract" and "… → Ellen LTC Contract", each with its own amount; pick the other spouse's contract under **To account** to move a line across. An account you type under `Custom…` is then offered in the **To account** list on every other line, and it

becomes a registration of its own: section 21's ending positions, the transfer sequence, the Roof growth rows and the report all show it by that name, with the tax type read from the name (Roth, IRA, after-tax) and the custodian you picked on the line.

The carrier list is Alto's October 2026 inventory of eighteen carriers plus Schwab and Fidelity; the product list opens with the generic families — `Savings`, `Checking`, `Money Market`, `CD`, `Fixed Indexed Annuity`, `MYGA`, `Managed portfolio` — and then that custodian's or carrier's own products, so pick the carrier first. A Foundation income line defaults to `Fixed Indexed Annuity`. A short name typed as an account's custodian in section 06 — *Athene*, *F&G*, *OneAmerica* — is enough to bring up the right product list. The last columns are worked out for you: what the source account has left after that line, and running totals for Foundation, Walls, Roof and Moat. Under the list sit the totals, the modelled target for each level, and the over (+) or under (−) against it. `Add a transfer` to split an account across two levels; delete a row to take that money out of your list. The page column is sized so the whole table fits on a wide screen; on a narrower one it scrolls sideways inside its panel with the account and the remove button held in view.

> **From your first edit, your list is the plan**
>
> The waterfall stops placing anything. Any money no row covers falls to the Roof as the residual — except life insurance cash value, which stays inside the policy. The footer tells you how much is in that position, and a note names the account.

Rows flag themselves as you go: Roth money leaving the Roof, qualified dollars into LTC, savings leaving cash, a life policy pointed anywhere but the Moat. A shortfall note tells you whether you caused it or the accounts always had it — *"$110,397 under the modelled target, the same as the proposal"* reads very differently from *"$610,000 more than the proposal, because these lines send that money elsewhere."*

Once you have taken the list over, two buttons appear. `Reset to proposed` re-seeds it from the waterfall's current figures. `Discard adjustments` hands the plan back entirely. The list itself sits behind the `Adjust Target Allocations` button beneath them — press it to open the table (the arrow turns), press again to tuck it away; Expand all opens it too.

Annuity income

A table under the transfer list with one row for every Foundation annuity contract above whose product is `Fixed Indexed Annuity` — the default for a Foundation line — named for the account it goes to (the from account is noted beneath; a line that stays put keeps its own name), with its carrier and amount. Lines sent to the same To account are one contract: their amounts add up into a single row, the from accounts are listed beneath with a “2 lines combined” note, both owners are named when the lines come from each spouse, and the row takes one set of income settings. Change a line's product and the table follows at once: pick a MYGA, a CD or a carrier's own product and the row drops out (that line then pays on the plan assumptions — the

Foundation yield from the first retirement, guaranteed per section 03); pick Fixed Indexed Annuity again and the row returns with its settings intact. For each you set `Guaranteed income` (Yes, No, or blank to follow section 03); when it is Yes, `Income starts`, the `Monthly income` and an `Inflation` rate the payment rises by each year, and the payment continues for life even after the contract's value is spent; when it is No, the share of the value `Withdrawn each month`, which stops when the value is gone. Blank cells follow the plan — income from the first retirement date, no inflation — and the placeholders show the figures that apply. The `Monthly income` cell is different: it starts filled with the calculated amount (the contract value at the Foundation yield, divided by twelve), shown in the muted "following the plan" style and recalculated as the transfers change. Type over it to set the carrier's quoted income; clear the cell and the calculated figure returns. Each annuity runs on its own in the projections; the hint beneath the table says what they pay in total at the start.

LTC benefits

One row per insured — the client's LTC contract and the spouse's — with every Moat line for that person in the transfer list added up into it: the row lists the accounts that fund it ("2 lines combined" when more than one), the carrier and product, and the combined premium. For each you can set the `Monthly benefit`, the age it is quoted `At` (80 by default), the `Benefit period` in years (5 by default) and an `Inflation` rider that raises the monthly benefit each year past that age (0% by default). Blank cells follow the Moat sizing: the person's target benefit from section 09 spread evenly over a five-year benefit period, from age 80, level, and the placeholders show those figures. Once a cell is set, the contract's benefit becomes monthly × 12 × years wherever the Moat's benefit is shown, and the care-event projections in sections 06 and 18 pay from each contract at its own yearly maximum for its own period before anything comes out of the accounts.

Roof growth

One row for every account the Roof lines go *to* — the Roth IRA, the after-tax account and so on — with the from accounts noted beneath, the combined amount, and an `Assumed growth` cell for each; a line that stays put keeps a row of its own. Blank follows the accounts' own rates from section 06 where typed (blended by amount when several feed one destination), otherwise the Roof growth rate in section 03; the `Default` column says which. The Roof grows at the amount-weighted blend of the rows, which the hint beneath reports and sections 16 and 17 use; the scenario strip shows the blended rate for each scenario.

Social Security claiming ages

The benefit starting age for this scenario, one select for each person. Blank follows the household's ages in section 04 (shown beside each); pick 62–70 to test a different claiming decision in this scenario alone — the hint beneath gives the resulting monthly benefit with its reduction or delayed credits. The income projection, the tax model, the stress tests and the reports built from this scenario all use the scenario's ages; the scenario strip has a **Social Security claimed at** row (an asterisk marks an age that departs from section 04), and section 04's Social Security table notes when the scenario showing claims at a different age. Section 04 keeps the base assumption and the claiming optimizer still writes there. Baseline always claims at the section 04 ages.

Walls income assumptions

Four fields for the Walls as adjusted: the `Walls yield`, when `Walls income starts`, and the Walls growth rate `before income starts` and `after`. Every field is blank by default and then follows section 03 and the first retirement date — the plan figure is shown under each label. Type a value and the projections in sections 15, 17 and 17, the worksheet and the Retirement Fortress Plan report follow it; the sizing in section 13 keeps the plan assumptions, so a lower yield here shows up as a Needs or Wants shortfall in the projections rather than a bigger target. A line beneath states the result in words, `Follow the plan assumptions` clears the annuity table and these four fields, and everything saves with the case. Every date in the projections — these, the retirement dates and each benefit's start and end — lands in the calendar year it names: a July 2030 start pays half a year in the 2030 row and the full amount from 2031.

15

READ

Adjusted Retirement Fortress Allocations

The plan as it stands after your adjustments in section 14 — the same bars and tiles as section 13, drawn from your list instead of the model's. Until you edit a line the two sections match and a note says so. Once your list is driving, the table beneath sets the two side by side for every level: the target, what the model funded, what your list funds, the change between them, and each level's share of household assets. Everything from here down — the projected assets, the transfer sequence, the ending positions and both PDFs — is built on this allocation, never on section 13.

At the foot of the section, **Income by source** stacks every dollar the household lives on each year to the `End of plan age` — salaries while they last, Social Security, pensions, annuity income (the Foundation annuity plus any contracts already paying), the Walls yield, non-guaranteed income and what the plan draws from the accounts in the section 17 order, RMDs taken beyond the draw included — with a dark red tick on each bar for that year's total expenses. Retired years are shaded and the first RMD year marked; hover a year for every figure including the tax. The table beneath carries each source, all income, Needs, Wants, total expenses, **Income tax** (federal plus state, from the section 17 projection; hover a cell for the split) and **Net cash flow** (all income less total expenses less income tax): before retirement that is the after-tax salary surplus, and in retirement it is zero because the plan withdraws exactly what expenses and both taxes require.

16

INPUT

Investment Portfolio

The household's investments as Nitrogen sees them. Print the *Investment Portfolio Proposal* from Nitrogen for the current portfolio and press `Upload Nitrogen portfolio proposal`. The page reads the PDF itself, page by page, and lays out what it found; nothing leaves the page unless it runs inside Claude, where the figures it read are sent to Claude to write the two summaries. The proposal and its reading are saved with the case; `Clear` removes them, and `Read the text below` runs the reading again on the text in the *Report text* box, so a report that will not open as a PDF can be pasted.

The tiles

: The household's Risk Number from the questionnaire with its six-month comfort zone; the portfolio's Risk Number, coloured by how far it sits from the household's (green within five points, amber within fifteen, red beyond), with its own 95% six-month range; the portfolio value with the number of accounts and holdings; GPA against the benchmark's; and the total annual cost with expense ratios, tax drag and the dividend yield.

The holdings and The risk assessment

: Two short readings an advisor can read aloud. Inside Claude they are written by Claude from the figures the page read (never from guesses — every number comes from the PDF); elsewhere the page writes them itself from the same figures. Both say which.

Asset classification

: Stocks, bonds, cash and other as Nitrogen classifies the holdings, the benchmark's split beside each. Index-linked annuity segments land in *other*, because Nitrogen models them through proxy funds rather than as stocks or bonds.

By holding type · By Risk Number

: The money by what it is in — annuity contracts, cash and money market, ETFs, single stocks, mutual funds — and by the Risk Number of each holding, in five bands.

Largest positions · Single-stock exposure

: The ten largest holdings combined across accounts, cash aside, each with its Risk Number and the account it sits in when there is one; then Nitrogen's stock intersection — the single stocks held directly and through funds, as a share of the equities.

Holdings by account

: Every account in the proposal with its Risk Number, total and GPA, and under it every holding: ticker, type, amount, share of the account and of the portfolio, SEC yield, the holding's Risk Number and GPA, and its 95% six-month range. Check the account totals against the PDF before the figures travel.

Stress tests · Performance · Sectors, regions, size and style

: Nitrogen's historical stress tests with the index it pairs with each, the trailing returns and the statistics against the benchmark, the equity and bond sectors, the regions, market cap and style, and the diversification figures — the points the holdings' relationships take off the Risk Number and the share of the benchmark's upside and downside the portfolio captures.

It reads; it does not change the plan

This section is for understanding the current portfolio. It does not change the accounts in section 06, the risk score in section 12 or any allocation. The reading is by Nitrogen's labels, so a report in a different layout may show fewer figures; a page the parser does not recognise is skipped, not guessed.

17

INPUT

Strategic Tax Planning

Everything in this section runs on the **adjusted** allocation in section 15 — the plan as it stands after your transfers in section 14, not the model's own in section 13. Change a line there and the withdrawal draws, the Roth conversion schedule and the year-by-year table all re-run.

How retirement income is drawn for tax: the **withdrawal order**, a **Roth conversion analysis**, then a year-by-year **projection of federal and state income tax** to the end of plan.

Withdrawal order

Three tiers, spent from the top down: **taxable** accounts (non-qualified brokerage, savings and cash), **tax-deferred** accounts (IRAs, 401(k)s, rollovers and deferred annuities) and **Roth** accounts. That is the default order — it keeps tax-deferred money compounding and leaves tax-free money for last — and the arrows on each tier move it up or down; `Reset to default order` puts it back. Each tier lists the accounts from section 06 that fall into it, with balances and a subtotal, so the order is read against the client's actual money. The order drives the tax projection below: whatever Needs and Wants need beyond the plan's income is drawn tier by tier.

Roth conversion analysis

Builds a conversion schedule: each year from the `start year` until the year before RMDs begin, it converts as much qualified money in the Walls and Roof as fits under the top of the `target tax bracket` — by default the bracket the household sits in during its first full retirement year — without pushing modified AGI over an IRMAA threshold once either person is within two years of Medicare (`Medicare premiums (IRMAA)` picks which of the five 2026 thresholds to stay under — the first keeps the standard premium — or none), since the surcharge is set from income two years back. `Social Security taxation` adds a second guard: keep provisional income (AGI before benefits, plus tax-exempt interest, plus half the benefits) under the 50% or the 85% threshold in any year benefits are paid, so a conversion does not pull more of the benefit into taxable income. Those thresholds are not indexed and most retired households already exceed them; the schedule then converts nothing in those years and names the threshold as the limit. The note beneath the controls states both guards in dollars. `Convert from` picks Roof first or Walls first. The tiles compare the plan with and without the strategy: amount converted, tax on the conversions, lifetime tax saved, Roth and tax-deferred balances at the end of plan, and total assets at the end. A bar chart shows the conversion each year with the tax on it, and the schedule lists every year in the window with what limited it (bracket, IRMAA, funding or nothing left). With `Apply the conversion strategy` ticked, the tax projection below and the asset projection in section 18 run with the conversions in; untick it to see the plan without them.

Required minimum distributions, with and without the conversion strategy

Under the conversion chart, the client's projected RMDs year by year as two bars per year: the required distribution without converting (blue) beside the one with the strategy (purple), from the year RMDs begin to the end of plan, with the figure without conversions written above every fifth year and the peak. Four tiles give the totals over the plan with and without, the required distributions avoided and their share, and the first RMD year with the amount each way; the note beneath reads the chart in words. The comparison is always drawn — with `Apply` unticked the purple bars show what the strategy would do and are labelled “not applied”. Hover a year for both figures, the difference and the tax-deferred balance each way. Distributions not needed for spending are reinvested in the Roof in both runs; what changes is how much is forced into taxable income.

Qualified charitable distributions

Gifts to charity paid straight from an IRA from age 70½. Enter each person's `annual gift` in today's dollars (it grows with inflation and is capped at the IRS limit — $111,000 a person in 2026, indexed — and at the balance), the `from age` (71 by default, the first full year after 70½) and whether the gifts are `already in the spending budget` (the QCD replaces cash gifts that sit in Needs and Wants, and the freed cash meets spending or is reinvested like spare RMD money) or `new giving` on top of it. Each year's QCD comes out of that person's tax-deferred balances, counts toward their required minimum distribution and is excluded from income, so it never raises taxable Social Security, the bracket or IRMAA. Four tiles: the total given from the IRA, the RMD income avoided (the part of each year's required distribution the gift satisfies), the **lifetime tax saved** against making the same gifts in cash under the standard deduction (where a cash gift is not deductible, so the saving is the full marginal rate on each gift, federal and state), and assets at the end of plan each way. The chart stacks the gift on the taxable RMD left after it, year by year, with the RMD giving in cash instead as a dashed line; hover for the figures and the tax each way that year. With `Apply` ticked the whole plan — the tax, RMD and asset projections and the report — runs with the QCDs; unticked, the comparison still shows what they would do. The status quo never has them. Each scenario keeps its own settings, and they save with the case. With the Roth strategy on, the conversions re-size around the QCDs, so the end-of-plan asset figure moves with both.

Projected income tax

Five tiles — lifetime federal tax, lifetime state tax, average effective rate (all tax over all income), the highest federal bracket reached and when RMDs begin — then three charts with a bar for every year: **taxable income**; the **effective federal rate**, each bar coloured by the highest federal bracket that year reaches (lighter to darker as the rate rises) with the rate written inside; and **federal and state tax** stacked. On all three the year RMDs begin is picked out with a tinted column and a dashed marker. Beneath them a table for every year to the end of plan: all income, taxable Social Security, withdrawals by tier, RMDs, AGI, deductions, taxable income, the bracket, the federal tax and effective rate, the state tax, all tax and the combined effective rate. Income is the same projection the section 13 chart uses — wages to each retirement date, Social Security, pensions, annuities, non-guaranteed income, the Foundation annuity and the Walls yield — plus required minimum distributions on the tax-deferred market balances and whatever has to be drawn, in the withdrawal order, to meet Needs and Wants and the tax itself. It files jointly with a spouse on file, single otherwise, and takes the standard deduction with the extra amount at 65 (and the $6,000 senior deduction while it lasts, 2025–2028). Hover the chart for any year's figures.

What the tax figures assume

2026 federal law (the One Big Beautiful Bill Act figures), with brackets, the standard deduction and the capital-gains thresholds indexed at the plan's inflation rate; the Social Security thresholds are not indexed, so up to 85% of benefits becomes taxable over time. Wages, pensions, non-guaranteed income, tax-deferred withdrawals and RMDs are ordinary income; the Foundation annuity is taxed by its funding (qualified money fully, a non-qualified annuity half); the non-qualified share of the Walls yield and half of each taxable-account withdrawal are long-term gains. RMDs follow the Uniform Lifetime Table from 73 or 75 by birth year; an RMD larger than the plan's own tax-deferred draw is taxed, spent first and otherwise reinvested in the after-tax Roof account. Both spouses are assumed living to the end of plan; no itemising, credits or IRMAA.

State tax follows the state in section 02 through a planning model of each state's 2025 rates and brackets, standard deduction or personal exemptions, and retirement-income rules — Pennsylvania, Illinois and Mississippi leave pension, IRA and annuity income untaxed; New York, Georgia, South Carolina, Maryland and others exclude a set amount per person from a given age; Social Security is exempt except where the state taxes it. Nine states have no income tax. Local income taxes (Maryland counties, Ohio and Pennsylvania municipalities, New York City) are not included. The whole projection is a planning estimate, not tax advice, and prints in the worksheet under *Projected income tax*.

Where an account lands

Tax type decides it: Non-Qualified is taxable, Qualified is tax-deferred, Roth is Roth. Two exceptions: a non-qualified account in the *Annuity* position is tax-deferred, and a life or LTC policy is left out — it is not a withdrawal source. The order saves with the case and prints in the worksheet under *Tax — withdrawal order*; it changes the tax projection, not the Fortress sizing.

18
READ

Projected Retirement Assets

What is left each year after the withdrawals in section 17, in total and by Fortress level, to the end of plan. Five tiles — assets today, at full retirement, at the end of plan, total withdrawn beyond the plan's income, and the peak (or the year the accounts run out) — then a stacked bar for every year: liquidity buffer, Foundation annuity, Walls, Roof, Moat and anything held outside

the plan, with the total labelled every fifth year and the year RMDs begin marked. A table beneath carries every year.

> **How the balances move**
>
> Balances start from the plan's own transfers in section 14 and roll forward a year at a time on the section 03 rates: the Walls at the Walls growth rate (after the Walls yield is paid), the Roof at the Roof growth rate, accounts left in place at the Walls rate, the liquidity buffer as cash with no growth. The Foundation annuity falls by the income it pays (and keeps paying for life if `Guaranteed lifetime income` is Yes); the Moat is an LTC contract, shown at the amount placed while it pays out. Withdrawals are the section 17 draws — what Needs and Wants (and the tax on the draw) need beyond the plan's income — taken in the withdrawal order, cash first within each tier, then Walls, then Roof; RMDs above the plan's own tax-deferred draw are spent first and otherwise reinvested after tax in the Roof. Future dollars with no market variation: a planning estimate, and it prints in the worksheet under *Projected retirement assets*.

If a long term care event occurs

Under the chart, the same three care-event projections as section 06 — male, female, both — run through the plan as adjusted. The insured's Moat benefit pays first and falls as it does (the Moat bar shrinks); anything above the benefit comes out of the accounts in the withdrawal order, with the tax on the draw. The tiles show the cost of care, how much the Moat paid, what came from the accounts and where the plan ends against the projection without a care event. Set against the same charts in section 06, they show what the Moat is for.

19
READ

Sensitivity Analysis

The section 18 projection for the scenario being viewed, run again under three stresses one at a time with everything else unchanged, each with its own tiles, chart and note and the base case drawn as a dashed line:

Sequence of returns risk

The Walls earn −4% and the Roof −15% a year in the first three years of full retirement (from the year after the last retirement date), then return to the assumed rates. The chart marks where the bad years begin; the tiles show the returns, what is withdrawn, the lowest point and where the plan ends against the base case.

Social Security cut

Benefits 22% lower from 2032 — the year the trust fund is projected to be depleted — for everyone, with the tax on Social Security following the reduced benefit. The tiles total the benefit lost over the plan.

Higher inflation

Long-term inflation 30% above the section 03 assumption (3.9% instead of 3.0%, say), applied to Needs and Wants and to the indexing of the tax brackets alike. The tiles total the extra spending over the plan.

The stresses use the scenario's own transfers, annuity income, Roof growth and Roth strategy, so each scenario has its own set. The report carries them after the projected assets, a full page for each.

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READ

Transfer sequence and ending positions

Section 20 is the paperwork in order. **Step 1** consolidates everything at the new custodian — qualified plans into one Rollover IRA per owner, Roth into one Roth IRA per owner, after-tax into a single joint account. **Step 2** moves the Foundation and Moat allocations on to the carriers. A **Stays put** block covers what never moves. Both steps follow section 14: each source account shows what each part of it is going to, Step 2 names the carrier and product you picked (marked *set in 06*), and a line sent to a different custodian than the consolidation is flagged as needing its own registration.

Read the flags on each row before you generate paperwork. They catch the things that reject transfers or surprise clients: a registration mismatch, an in-force annuity that will not move by ACATS, a surrender charge worth checking, capital gains from liquidating a taxable position.

Section 21 is where every account lands, plus assets under management and the advisory fee. The fee schedule is flat, not marginal — wherever the managed total falls, that band's rate applies to the whole balance. Billable assets are the Walls and Roof only; the cash buffer, the Foundation annuity and the Moat contracts are out. The **weighted average** spreads that same cost across everything in the plan, which is the number a client will ask about.

> **Two rules the tool will not let you break**
>
> Long-term care contracts are always individually owned — each insured gets their own policy, even when one joint account funds both, and the tool flags the change of title.
>
> With no spouse on file, nothing is titled Joint or Spouse. If an account is still marked that way you will see a flag naming it; fix it in section 06 or add the spouse.

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OUTPUT

The five downloads

Three of these go to a client. The other two are marked *not for client distribution* on every page. `Scenario for the reports` at the top of the section picks which of the three scenarios they are built from — the same choice as `Use for reports` in section 14. When it is not the scenario showing, the page switches to it while the documents build and switches back; the educational slides are the same whichever is chosen. `Plan status` beside it marks Your Retirement Fortress Plan **Draft** or **Final**: the cover reads *Draft — for discussion* or *Final plan* and the same stamp sits at the foot of every page. The choice is saved with the case; a new case starts as a draft.

CLIENT-FACING

Your Retirement Fortress Plan

An HTML slide document of about 50 pages (a page more with a Nitrogen report uploaded, with qualified charitable distributions applied, and when the consolidation list runs past ten lines, plus the appendix) in Alto's template style — Montserrat throughout, the logo on every page, no text smaller than 16 point, annuities always called annuities — for the client meeting: goals, household, income and the income gap, expenses (the detailed budget, when one is completed, prints in the appendix), assets and net worth with a tax-type pie, the status-quo projection, the cost of long-term care and then the status-quo projection with a care event added, life insurance, legacy, risk, the current investment portfolio when a Nitrogen report is uploaded, the Fortress framework graphic, the Fortress in dollars, a page each on what is in the Foundation, Walls, Roof and Moat, income by source, the initial withdrawal order, Roth, the required minimum distributions with and without the conversions (totals, the distributions avoided and the two-bar chart by year), the qualified charitable distributions when applied (what is given, the RMD income avoided, the lifetime tax saved against cash gifts, the IRS limit and the stacked chart by year), the tax rate and tax bill year by year, projected assets (and the same with a long term care event), the three stress tests — a full page each for the bad start to retirement, the Social Security cut and higher inflation — the ending positions (the transfer sequence itself prints in the appendix: *What Moves Where, and in What Order*, then *Then, Fund the Protected Pieces* with

CLIENT-FACING

Social Security analysis

The claiming optimizer's findings as a letter-size client report, *Social Security Planning Analysis*: a cover with the client names, date and advisor; an introduction and key terms (PIA, full retirement age, COLA, life expectancy, spousal and survivor benefits, with the FRA and percentage-of-PIA reference tables); the inputs and assumptions; the six scenarios (the highest lifetime benefit, both at 70, both at 62, one early and the other late, both at full retirement age) with their claiming events, lifetime totals and rank among everything tested, and where the plan's own ages rank; bar charts of lifetime benefits with and without the reduction, the surviving spouse's first full-year income, the cumulative chart and the break-even table; a year-by-year schedule for each strategy; how to file; and what the analysis leaves out, with the AEWM disclosures. It opens in a new tab and prints to Letter pages from the browser. It needs a PIA in section 04.

each Foundation annuity contract's carrier, product and income terms, each LTC contract's premium and benefit, the accounts that fund them, anything left in place, and the totals), then how the picture improves, what it costs, working with Alto and the moving parts. A **Contents** page with page numbers follows the cover, and an **Appendix Contents** page opens the appendix. After the closing page the appendix prints the detailed monthly budget when one is completed, then the personal cash flow statement from section 18 as tables — income by source, then the cash flow and ending balances, about fourteen years to a page, with any shortfall before withdrawals in red; the transfer sequence (*What Moves Where, and in What Order*, every consolidation line with its destination, then *Then, Fund the Protected Pieces*, each annuity and LTC contract with what funds it); and, when a Nitrogen proposal is loaded in section 16, the investment portfolio in full — every account and holding (sixteen rows to a page), the stress tests and performance statistics, sectors, regions, size and style, and the largest positions and single stocks. The same proposal adds one page to the main deck after the withdrawal-order page, *Your Investment Portfolio Summary*: the five tiles, the two readings shortened to their first sentences, the asset classification and the stress tests. The charts are the tool's own, carried over as drawn; every figure comes from the same run as the PDFs. It opens in a new browser tab; when a file is needed, the browser's Print → Save as PDF gives a 16:9 PDF (20 × 11.25 in), one page per topic, with margins set to none and background graphics on. A view that does not allow new tabs saves the `.html` file instead.

CLIENT-FACING

Educational slides

Alto's *Protecting Your Retirement Income* deck as a 24-page PDF, carried inside the tool and the same for every client: the three core principles, market cycles and sequence-of-returns risk, the protected-income approach, fixed and indexed annuities, downside protection, the Fortress levels, a slide on long-term care in America — the need, the average length of care and the 2025 median costs — and three closing slides on required minimum distributions: how the starting age moved from 70½ to 73 and to 75 from 2033, the Uniform Lifetime Table percentages by age, and the compression effect of a later start. It needs no case loaded. Use it for the first meeting or as a leave-behind; to update the deck, replace the file in the tool.

INTERNAL ONLY

Internal worksheet

The full audit trail — assumptions, targets versus funding, both transfer steps, every item flagged for confirmation, and any transfer you set by hand recorded against the waterfall's own proposal.

INTERNAL ONLY

Nitrogen account upload

A bare list of ending positions named `Owner's Custodian Tax type (Level)` for keying into risk analysis.

Before the Retirement Fortress Plan report leaves the office

Its disclosure pages are a draft. Have compliance approve that language — and the AEWM paragraph in particular — before you hand it to anyone. Check that both carriers are named rather than "TBD", and read the fee figures once against what the client will actually be charged.

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SAVE

Saving and reopening a case

Press `Copy case data` and paste the block into your CRM note, an email to yourself, wherever the case file lives. It carries the household, every account, and any transfers you adjusted

by hand.

To pick it back up, paste the block into the same box and press `Load pasted case`. Everything comes back, including your adjustments, re-pointed at the right accounts. If the block was saved in a file, press `Upload case file` instead and pick it — a Word document (.docx), a plain text file or a .json file; other text around the block is ignored and Word's curly quotes are straightened. An older .doc, a PDF or a Pages file won't open; save it as .docx or .txt first.

Do this before every meeting where you might change something, and again at the end. It takes five seconds and it is the only backup that exists.

Saved cases on Alto's site

When the Blueprint runs on Alto's own site rather than as the claude.ai demo, you sign in with your Microsoft account and a **Saved cases** panel appears above the paste box. `Save` keeps the open case on Alto's server under the client's name and your sign-in, and saving again updates the same record; `Save as new` makes a second copy; `Open` brings one back; `Delete` removes it from the list (an administrator can restore it for 30 days); `Export all` downloads every case you can see as one JSON file. Advisors see their own cases; the firm's administrators see all of them. The written summaries in sections 12 and 16 run there too, through Alto's server, so nothing but the figures on the page is sent to Claude. The paste box keeps working alongside the panel, and the signed-in name fills the `Advisor` field on a new case.

Notes

WORTH KNOWING

Things that catch people out

- **No Cash row, no buffer.** The liquidity buffer only funds from accounts marked **Cash**. If the household's savings came in as Market, the buffer sits empty and the Foundation looks wrong.
- **The LTC cost defaults fight you until you type.** Changing a person's age or sex rewrites their average LTC cost — but only until you have edited that field yourself, after which your figure sticks.
- **Yields are assumptions you are publishing.** Whatever you set appears in the client summary's disclosures as an assumed rate. Set them to something you can defend.
- **Held-back accounts leave the fee base twice.** An account marked **Stay as is** is out of billable AUM *and* out of the weighted-average denominator, which raises that percentage. That is deliberate — you should not average a fee across money you are not managing.
- **An account named "Joint brokerage" keeps that name.** The tool never titles a registration Joint for a single client, but it will not rename an account you typed. Rename it in section 06 if it should not appear that way on a client document.
- **Refresh is fatal.** Worth saying twice.

Internal use only. This guide describes an internal planning tool. The tool produces illustrations based on stated assumptions, not projections or guarantees, and no output constitutes a recommendation until a suitability review is complete.

Retirement Fortress© is a proprietary planning framework of Alto Financial Group. Alto Financial Group offers investment advisory services through AE Wealth Management, LLC (AEWM), an affiliated Registered Investment Adviser. Neither Alto Financial Group nor its representatives may give tax or legal advice.